

Dear Wilhelm,

Your letter arrived Tuesday and I have read it three times, chiefly because I could hear you preening through the ink. A repaired road, an honest butcher, a Bürgermeister shaking your hand in the square – you built the town a clock and it has thanked you by becoming respectable. I am delighted for you, old friend, and not at all surprised. You never could make a thing that worked only as well as it needed to.

The physician's idle winter and the Brauer boy's arm I will grant you, though I suspect the credit belongs to the physician and to the boy. But zero uneven joints in the whole of the road – did you truly count them? Of course you did. You counted the stones of my garden path the summer you stayed with us, and informed me that two were loose.

As for your woodcarver and his four identical chairs: Wilhelm, you are making too much of a clock. A man may find his best pattern late in life and be content to repeat it. If Renner has stopped fussing and started producing, his customers are the richer for it, and so is he. Not every regularity in the world is your doing. It is a fine tower and an honest one, and I will not have you inventing troubles to deprive yourself of a triumph.

*Write to me when the spring fairs open. I should like to see this
marvel of yours with my own eyes before you find something in it to worry
about. You always do.*

Your friend,

Kohler